

CHAPTER 31 — The Profile

Tuesday began with a photograph Zoe chose not to open.

It sat in the corner of the screen as a thumbnail attached to an old recipient file.

RCP-0447 — FAMILY REFERENCE IMAGE SET

Three images.

Zoe moved the cursor over them.

“Adults?”

“Probably,” Elias said.

“Children?”

“Could be.”

She closed the preview.

“Then we don’t need them.”

Elias said nothing.

He didn’t have to.

Room Twelve looked different in daylight. Less like somewhere they had hidden for the night and more like what it really was: a cheap room beside a bypass, overlooking the service yard of a plumbing supplier.

A van reversed below.

Someone shouted, “Keep coming.”

Someone else shouted, “Stop.”

The van kept coming.

Zoe watched for a second.

“Excellent teamwork.”

Elias was already at the desk.

She sat beside him and opened the notebook.

The question from the night before waited at the top of the page.

**What do they choose in the adults before they
choose the child?**

RCP-0447 was as good a place as any to find out.

They already knew the basics.

Two adults.

One child wanted.

Permanent placement.

A child between six and nine.

Low likelihood of disclosure.

High likelihood of attachment.

Completed match.

No names.

No address.

Nothing that required them to know who the child was.

Zoe found the section they had skipped before.

Motive.

Yesterday it had been letters and numbers.

Today they found the key.

The computer translated them into three things.

Child loss.

Unable to have another child.

Failed lawful adoption.

Zoe stopped.

All three belonged to the same household.

For a few seconds she listened to the van below beeping backwards.

"They had a child."

Elias looked at the screen.

"They lost one."

"Then they couldn't have another."

He waited.

"And they tried to adopt."

"Looks that way."

"And got turned down."

"Yes."

Zoe leaned back.

"That's horrible."

"The rejection?"

"All of it."

She looked again.

There was something worse hiding inside the sequence.

Not what had happened to the couple.

What somebody had done with it.

"They knew."

"Who?"

"The people running this."

Elias folded his arms.

"Knew what?"

"That these people wanted a child badly enough to keep trying."

"That seems supported."

"And that they'd just been told no."

"Also supported."

Zoe frowned at him.

"You could just agree occasionally."

"I did."

"No. You performed an evidential assessment."

"That is agreement."

"It really isn't."

She looked back at the screen.

Someone had lost a child.

Someone had been told there would not be another pregnancy.

Someone had tried the proper route and failed.

Then this system had found them.

Or someone inside it had.

That was the part Zoe wanted.

She moved towards the assessment summary.

Elias put one finger against the desk.

"Before you open it."

"I know."

"Do you?"

“Yes.”

She did.

The file could contain everything.

Medical reports.

Money.

Arguments.

Sex.

Mental health.

Things people had said when they thought they were speaking privately.

Grief recorded by strangers.

The archive made curiosity very easy.

Zoe disliked that about it.

She opened only the field list.

No answers.

Just the things the system had measured.

Loss.

Fertility.

Adoption history.

Finances.

Relationship stability.

Social network.

Secrecy.

Sponsor relationship.

Preferred age.

Preferred sex.

Appearance.

Then one that stopped her.

PRIOR CHILD ANCHOR

Zoe read it twice.

“What’s an anchor?”

“In this context?”

“That’s why I asked.”

“Something the match is built around.”

She stared at the words.

Prior child.

“No.”

Elias said nothing.

She searched the definition without opening the family’s narrative.

There were several possible anchors.

A family trait.

An imagined child.

A previous child.

This household had the last one.

Zoe felt the idea arrive and immediately wanted it to be wrong.

“If they lost a child...”

“Careful.”

“I am being careful.”

"Finish the sentence carefully."

She scowled.

Then tried again.

"If the previous child is part of the match, they might be looking for things that remind the adults of them."

Elias nodded once.

"That's supportable."

"That's disgusting."

"That is an opinion."

"I know. I'm keeping it."

She wrote one question.

**Did they deliberately match resemblance to the
child who died?**

Underneath:

DON'T ASSUME.

She hated writing the second line.

Which was probably why it belonged there.

* * *

Voss found the first answer in a cardboard box.

Vale was sitting on the floor surrounded by old contractor records, one boot tucked underneath her, when he passed her a receiving sheet from 2018.

No names.

No photograph.

Only the route they had already matched to the old placement.

Vale read the handwritten note at the bottom.

Visual confirmation requested prior to acceptance.

She looked up.

"Confirmation of what?"

"Could be identity."

"Before acceptance?"

Voss took the page back.

Below it was another line.

Recipient response: APPROVED

Vale pulled the next sheet from the file.

Transport instruction.

Ordinary route code.

Ordinary contractor language.

Then three words:

Prior viewing completed.

She went still. "Viewing." Voss kept reading. "Apparently." "Of the child?" "Likely." "How?" "Doesn't say." "Photograph?" "Could be." "In person?" "Could be." "Behind glass?" Voss looked at her. "You're ahead of the paper." Vale exhaled. "Fine." She put the sheet down.

What bothered her was how little the paperwork had bothered anybody at the time.

Children met prospective carers.

Carers saw photographs.

Introductions happened.

Compatibility was assessed.

Nothing on the page announced itself as trafficking.

Nothing said buyer.

Nothing said sale.

Nothing said stolen child.

It looked close enough to legitimate work that everybody handling one small part could keep moving.

Vale tapped the words again.

Prior viewing completed.

"The strange thing isn't that it looks strange."

Voss glanced at her.

"It doesn't."

"Exactly."

* * *

By ten twenty-three, Zoe had found the matching table.

She nearly groaned.

"No."

Elias looked over. "What?"

"More numbers."

"You like numbers."

"I like numbers when they aren't trying to ruin people."

"That narrows the field."

She gave him a look. "Was that another joke?"

"No."

"Your condition is getting worse."

The table was smaller than the earlier ones. One household. One child. A list of things the system had compared. Age. Sex. Health. Behaviour.

Preferences. Attachment.

Appearance.

The previous child.

Zoe skipped most of the scores.

One thing was obvious without copying them all.

Appearance had been given a lot of importance.

So had predicted attachment.

The previous-child match was almost as high as it could go.

She stopped scrolling.

"Elias."

He leaned closer.

She pointed.

The system had not simply recorded that the adults had lost a child.

It had used that dead child as part of the calculation.

The matched child strongly resembled what the household profile called the prior-child anchor.

Another field showed unusually strong physical correspondence.

Zoe stared at the screen.

No photograph was needed now.

No dead child's name.

No face.

The numbers were enough.

"They measured it."

"Yes."

She turned towards him.

“They actually measured how much the new child would remind them of the one who died.”

“That appears to be what this says.”

Zoe looked back at the screen.

A grieving couple.

A child brought in front of them.

Familiar enough to hurt.

Familiar enough to feel important.

Maybe the same hair.

Maybe the same eyes.

Maybe nothing obvious to anyone else.

Just enough.

“They made it look like fate.”

Elias was quiet.

Zoe rubbed her arms.

“That sounds dramatic.”

“It doesn’t make it wrong.”

She wished it did.

The adults would see a child.

The system would see probability.

Recognition.

Preference.

Attachment.

A match.

"That's horrible."

Elias closed one of the windows.

Zoe looked at him.

"And clever."

He did not answer.

"That's the worst bit."

"I know."

* * *

The chronology gave them the rest without requiring the private assessment.

Eight years before the placement, the couple's biological child had died.

Months later, fertility treatment ended without another pregnancy.

Several years after that they entered the lawful adoption process.

They were assessed.

Then declined.

Four months later, a sponsor appeared.

Zoe read the dates again.

"Four months."

Elias moved the laptop towards himself.

"Yes."

"After they were rejected."

"Yes."

"That's when someone approached them."

"That's when the sponsor appears in this record."

She sighed.

"Fine. That."

There had been several attempted matches afterwards.

One failed.

Another fell below whatever threshold the system used.

One was withdrawn.

Then the eventual child appeared.

Accepted.

Zoe stared at the gaps between the dates. "They waited." "Looks like it." "They didn't just find any child." "No." "They waited for the right one." Elias said nothing. The sponsor code was K08. Unknown to them. But the

pattern felt familiar. Someone outside the household had opened the door. Someone who somehow knew the lawful route had failed. "How would they know?" "Lots of possibilities." "Friend." "Possibly." "Family." "Possibly." "Someone from the adoption process." "Possible." "Someone they complained to."

"Possible."

"Someone watching rejected applications."

Elias looked at her.

"Possible. No evidence."

Zoe wrote:

Sponsor appears four months after adoption refusal. Source unknown.

She disliked source unknown because it felt like losing.

It wasn't.

It was just true.

* * *

Vale found the dead child before lunch.

She did it without tracing the child who had been placed.

That rule had become important to both of them.

Adults only.

The receiving property led to two names through old public records.

One of those names led to a local newspaper article.

Vale opened it.

A couple stood beside a hospital donation.

Between them was an oversized cheque.

The article explained why.

Their four-year-old son had died after a short illness.

Years earlier.

Long before the placement.

Vale read enough.

Then closed the photograph.

Voss looked at her.

"Name?"

"We don't need it."

He nodded.

Another public record showed one of the adults later involved with an adoption charity.

It did not prove they had applied.

It certainly did not prove they had been rejected.

But it fitted the archive.

Vale wrote:

Child loss independently confirmed.

Then:

Later adoption interest consistent.

Then, after a moment:

Rejection only supported by shadow record.

Voss read the page.

"Keep it that way."

"I was going to."

"I know."

She closed the browser.

The dead boy's face was still in her mind.

She resented that.

"They used him."

Voss looked at the contractor sheet.

"We don't know how much information came from where."

"They used the fact he existed."

That, he could not argue with.

Vale picked up the page marked Prior viewing completed.

"Do you think they showed the couple a child who looked like him?"

Voss took longer this time.

"Zoe may be able to answer that."

Vale smiled faintly.

"She probably already has."

"Probably."

It was almost affectionate.

Which annoyed her more than it should have.

* * *

The lawful adoption rejection had three broad reasons attached to it.

Assessment concerns.

Unresolved grief.

Temporary financial instability.

Zoe read them once.

Then again.

"That's it?"

"That's what the index says."

"They weren't dangerous."

"Nothing here says they were."

"Not abusive."

"Nothing here says that either."

"Not criminals."

"Not at that point."

She looked at him.

"Right."

That was the part that changed everything.

If the network needed monsters, it would have to find monsters.

Monsters were rare.

Hurting people were everywhere.

A couple who had buried a child.

A couple who could not have another.

A couple who had gone through the proper process and been told they were not suitable.

Someone could arrive after that and tell them the rules were the problem.

You should have been approved.

You have a home.

There is a child who needs one.

Why should paperwork decide whether you get to be a family?

Zoe realised she had been staring at nothing.

"That argument works."

Elias watched her.

"I know it's wrong."

"I didn't say anything."

"But it works."

"Yes."

"That's what's horrible."

She got up and walked to the window.

Below, a man carried copper pipe across the yard.

Ordinary Tuesday.

Ordinary work.

Someone somewhere had probably made the same argument over a

kitchen table.

No talk of buying children.

No talk of stealing them.

Just unfair systems.

Private arrangements.

Confidential cases.

A child who needed a home.

A family who deserved one.

"And then the paperwork looks real," Zoe said.

"Enough of it."

"And they see the child."

"Sometimes."

"And they want to believe."

Elias leaned back.

"People rarely need a lie to be perfect."

She turned.

"What do they need?"

"A reason not to test it."

Zoe looked at the screen again.

The child could become that reason.

* * *

Another part of the recipient profile measured disclosure.

Not simply whether the adults would keep secrets.

What they actually knew.

The system had four levels.

At one end were recipients who believed everything was legitimate.

At the other were people actively helping the shadow operation.

RCP-0447 sat near the middle.

D2 — PARTIAL KNOWLEDGE

Zoe read the definition.

“They knew something was wrong.”

“Unusual,” Elias corrected.

“That’s generous.”

“It matters.”

She waited.

“They may have known normal adoption or placement rules were being bypassed. That does not prove they knew where the child came from.”

Zoe looked at D2 again.

“So they could know the route was dodgy without knowing the child was stolen.”

“Yes.”

“Could they know the paperwork was fake?”

“Possible.”

“Could they know there was no proper court approval?”

“Possible.”

“But we don’t know.”

“No.”

She tapped the notebook with the end of her pen.

“That’s annoying.”

“It should be.”

“Why?”

“Because certainty would be easier.”

She thought about Helen.

Then stopped herself.

This was not their file.

Not yet.

She wrote only:

**Recipient is not one thing. Find out what each adult
actually knew.**

The sentence felt less satisfying than declaring everyone guilty.

Which probably made it more useful.

* * *

The last matching field was called Controlled Visual Introduction.

Zoe froze.

Elias noticed immediately.

“What?”

She pointed.

The system had several ways to present a child to a recipient.

Documents.

Photographs.

Supervised introduction.

This one sat somewhere between them.

Controlled visual introduction.

"Viewing," Zoe said.

"Could be."

"Voss and Vale found 'prior viewing completed'."

"That would fit."

"And 'recipient approved'."

"Yes."

She felt cold despite the overheated room.

"How do you let an adult see a child without the child knowing they're being looked at?"

Elias did not answer.

He didn't need to.

A camera.

A window.

Another room.

Somewhere public.

Somewhere private.

Zoe's mind produced too many possibilities.

Then another thought tried to attach itself.

Helen.

Something Helen had once said.

Something about knowing.

The first moment.

Zoe could not remember the exact words.

She did not try.

Not evidence.

Not this household.

Not today.

She closed the laptop.

“Enough.”

Elias left it closed.

No argument.

Zoe appreciated that too.

* * *

They ate lunch beside a canal.

Cheese sandwiches.

Salt-and-vinegar crisps.

Apples.

Zoe also had a chocolate bar she had bought without consulting anyone.

Elias looked at it.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“You’re judging me.”

“I haven’t said anything.”

“You have eyebrows.”

He returned to his sandwich.

A narrowboat moved past at approximately the speed of continental drift.

Zoe watched it.

After a while she said, "They didn't put the children in bad homes."

Elias swallowed.

"We don't know that."

"You know what I mean."

"Say what you mean."

She hated when he did that.

"They cared whether the home worked."

"Apparently."

"Whether the adults would bond with the child."

"Yes."

"Whether the child would fit."

"Yes."

"So if it works..."

She stopped.

Across the canal, a dog dragged its owner towards a duck.

Zoe watched the argument develop.

"If it works," she said again, "nobody looking from outside sees the beginning."

Elias waited.

"School is normal."

"Maybe."

"Doctor."

"Maybe."

"Neighbours."

"Yes."

"Birthdays. Holidays. Family photos."

He looked at her then.

Zoe stared down at the chocolate wrapper.

"Home."

That word hurt.

Because Helen and Brian had been home.

Not a placement.

Not a file.

Not a receiving household.

Home.

Helen complaining about wet towels.

Brian leaving his shoes in the hall.

The stupid song Helen sang when she cooked.

The mug Zoe always used even though there were six identical ones.

None of that disappeared because something before it had been wrong.

"They can do something terrible," Zoe said quietly, "and then something real grows out of it."

Elias looked towards the canal.

"Yes."

"That's unfair."

"I know."

"Because then proving the terrible thing can hurt the real thing."

"Yes."

Zoe crushed the empty wrapper in her hand.

The network had understood that before she had.

That was what attachment meant.

Not simply whether the adults would love the child.

Whether, after enough years, losing the child would become unthinkable.

The family itself became something worth protecting.

Even from the truth.

"Leverage," she said.

Elias looked over.

"The child is the leverage."

"Sometimes."

"They don't have to threaten the adults."

"No."

"They just have to make them scared the truth will take the child away."

"Yes."

Zoe looked at the narrowboat disappearing around the bend.

Love did the rest.

She hated the thought because the love itself could still be real.

* * *

They stayed beside the canal longer than they needed to.

Zoe eventually reopened the notebook.

Two headings.

EXPOSE

PROTECT

Under the first she wrote: Adult authorisations. Payments. Sponsor accounts. False documents. Knowing decisions. Under the second: Children. Current homes. Schools. Medical information. Private grief that proved nothing. She paused. Then added: Legitimate placements. Elias read over her shoulder. "You're going to change that list."

"Obviously."

"Then why write it?"

"So I know what I'm changing from."

He considered that.

"Fair."

Zoe smiled.

"You nearly said good."

"I didn't."

"Growth."

* * *

At three twelve, Voss received a message from Zoe.

Four recipient-knowledge categories.

One short instruction beneath them.

Find what the old household actually knew. Paper only. No contact. No child tracing.

Vale read it over his shoulder.

"She's giving us homework."

Voss picked up the old receiving file.

"She's thirteen."

"That does not improve it."

They started with the handover paperwork.

Then invoices.

One payment stood out.

Not because it said anything dramatic.

Because it didn't.

SPECIAL ADMINISTRATION / PRIVATE ROUTE

Vale looked at the amount.

Too much to look like photocopying.

Too little to look like a price for a human being.

Explainable.

That seemed to be the network's favourite kind of number.

Another sheet showed the payment had moved through sponsor K08.

Then they found the acknowledgement.

Meridian paperwork.

Signed by both recipient adults.

Vale read the central paragraph aloud.

"Standard placement and adoption processes are not applicable to this arrangement."

She stopped.

Voss waited.

"Confidential administrative handling accepted as advised."

Neither spoke for a moment.

Vale read it again.

"They knew it wasn't normal."

"Yes."

"D2?"

"Looks like it."

"Not enough for deliberate trafficking."

"No."

She nodded reluctantly.

The next paragraph was worse.

Any legal or administrative query had to go through the sponsor.

Disclosure to third parties could threaten placement security.

Vale laughed once.

There was no humour in it.

"They tell them not to check."

"They tell them how to check."

"Through the person who arranged it."

"Yes."

"So if you get nervous, you ask the liar whether the lie is safe."

Voss folded the paper back.

"And the answer will be reassuring."

Vale stared at the two signatures.

Two grieving adults.

Desperate enough to take a route they knew was outside the normal system.

Possibly ignorant of how far outside.

Possibly willing not to ask.

She could not tell from the paper.

That was the uncomfortable part.

“They need people who can live with themselves afterwards,” she said.

Voss looked at her.

Vale tapped the acknowledgement.

“If they know they bought a stolen child, they know what they are.”

“Some do.”

“But these two?”

Voss waited.

“They get a story.”

“Yes.”

“Private arrangement. Bureaucracy failed. Child needed protecting. Everything confidential for their safety.”

“Yes.”

“A story they can keep telling themselves.”

Voss looked at the receiving sheet.

Recipient response: APPROVED.

“That would help.”

Vale did not like him agreeing.

It made the thought harder to escape.

* * *

At four twenty-six, Zoe received their message.

**D2 supported. Recipients signed
non-standard-route acknowledgement and**

sponsor-only query condition. Private administration payment confirmed. No proof

recipients knew child origin was fraudulent.

She read the last sentence twice.

No proof.

She underlined nothing.

Good.

The sentence stayed exactly as it was.

Elias read it beside her.

“They found it without the drive.”

“I know.”

That made it stronger.

The archive said D2.

The paper outside the archive showed adults knowingly accepted a non-standard route.

Not kidnapping.

Not fraud at source.

Not yet.

But enough to prove the archive’s categories described real behaviour.

Zoe looked at the sponsor-only condition again.

Every time someone became nervous, the system pointed them back inside itself.

Ask the sponsor.

Ask Meridian.

Ask the legal contact you were given.

Do not ask anyone outside.

The contractors had been given the same kind of world.

So had recipients.

Everyone was allowed to verify.

As long as they verified with the people who had supplied the answer.

Zoe imagined Helen hearing:

It's unusual because the case is sensitive.

Don't contact anyone directly.

You could put the child at risk.

She shut the thought down.

Not yet.

Her family could wait until evidence reached them.

For once, she would make the order.

* * *

That evening they left Room Twelve.

Elias wanted somewhere quieter.

They ended up in a guesthouse attached to a pub, which was not quieter in any known meaning of the word.

Zoe approved.

"There are witnesses."

"There are drunk people."

"Drunk witnesses."

"Worse."

"More enthusiastic."

Somebody downstairs cheered.

Neither knew why.

The drive stayed closed.

They had enough for one day.

Zoe sat cross-legged on the bed with the notebook.

The anonymous couple existed more clearly now than they had that morning.

They had lost a child.

Could not have another.

Tried adoption.

Were rejected.

A sponsor appeared.

The network assessed them.

Matched carefully.

Let them see the child somehow before accepting.

The adults knew their route was not normal.

They paid for private handling.

They agreed not to ask questions outside the chain.

Then the child became family.

Zoe looked at Elias.

"They don't recruit criminals."

He was reading.

"Some of them probably are."

"You know what I mean."

He lowered the book.

"Try again."

She made a face at him.

"They don't need criminals."

He waited.

"They need people who can do something wrong while still believing they're doing something right."

Elias closed the book.

"That's different."

"Better?"

"Yes."

Zoe stared at the ceiling.

The system did not merely find adults willing to break rules.

It found the reason each adult might forgive themselves for doing it.

Grief.

Desperation.

Anger.

Love.

Then it gave those feelings paperwork.

Afterwards, the match itself became protection.

A happy child.

A loving parent.

A normal school run.

A family that no longer felt temporary.

Zoe sat up.

"That's why the matching matters so much."

Elias waited.

"If they match badly, the placement falls apart."

"Likely."

"If they match well, the family bonds."

"Yes."

"And once they bond, telling the truth risks losing everything."

Elias watched her.

"So the better the family works..."

She stopped.

The sentence finished itself.

The better the family worked, the safer the secret became.

Zoe looked down at the notebook.

She did not write a slogan.

She didn't need one.

She would remember.

* * *

Before sleeping, she checked one last thing.

Not recipient details.

Only sponsor links.

K08 appeared repeatedly.

Eleven recipient profiles.

Then she searched AC019.

Mac's account.

Seven.

Zoe stared at the number.

Elias saw it from across the room.

Neither spoke for a few seconds.

"Seven profiles," Zoe said finally.

"Correct."

"Not seven children."

"Correct."

She wrote that down immediately.

**AC019 — 7 RECIPIENT PROFILES. DOES NOT
MEAN 7 CHILDREN.**

Even with the warning, the number changed Mac.

He was no longer simply attached to her file.

His account touched multiple receiving households.

Multiple.

She wanted to open them.

Every one.

Names.

Dates.

Matches.

Children.

She moved the cursor away.

"No."

Elias had not said anything.

"I know."

She closed the search.

The day had begun with a photograph she did not open.

It could end the same way.

Knowing something existed did not give her the right to consume it.

The network had treated private lives as material.

A dead child became a matching factor.

Infertility became motive.

Rejection became opportunity.

Love became leverage.

Zoe had its archive now.

She did not have to inherit its habits.

Downstairs, somebody laughed so hard they started coughing.

A glass smashed.

People applauded.

Zoe looked towards the floor.

"Why are they clapping?"

"I have no idea."

"Adults are weird."

"Yes."

She smiled.

Then opened the notebook to a clean page.

Tomorrow.

The last test had asked one question and watched Meridian react.

This time she wanted three.

Different pieces.

Different adult channels.

One about Meridian.

One about money linked to a sponsor.

One about the legal side of the false paperwork.

Nothing about children.

Nothing about current families.

Nobody receiving enough information to understand the whole test.

Elias came over.

“What are you doing?”

“Making them nervous.”

“That is not a methodology.”

“It is at thirteen.”

He almost smiled.

Almost.

Zoe drew three small boxes.

DOCUMENT

MONEY

LEGAL

“If these parts are really separate, they should react separately.”

“And if they aren’t?”

“Then somebody moves.”

She looked at him.

"Or calls someone."

"Possibly."

"And if two different questions make the same hidden people panic..."

"React."

Zoe sighed.

"You really hate fun."

"Precision."

"Same problem."

She closed the notebook.

The photograph from that morning remained unopened.

So did the private assessment.

So did six other recipient profiles linked to Mac.

She knew enough.

That was new too.

Before the drive, answers had always felt scarce.

Now the danger was believing she deserved every answer simply because she could reach it.

Zoe lay back against the pillow.

The network had looked at a grieving family and asked:

What can this pain make them do?

She stared at the ceiling for a long time.

Her own question was harder.

What could she prove without taking anything else from people who had already lost enough?

Downstairs, another cheer shook the floor.

She would give three different parts of the machine three different reasons to be afraid.

Then she would watch which ones called each other.